

unaddressed. And yet, most continue. The Hippocratic oath, for many, is not just a ceremonial promise, it becomes a way of life.

THE WEIGHT THEY CARRY

Alongside the emotional demands of care, doctors often work within conditions that quietly test their endurance. While the country's doctor-patient ratio appears strong on paper, around 1:834, better than WHO's 1:1000 guideline, the urban-rural divide skews the reality. Rural India often sees a single doctor serving over 10,000 people, and in some blocks, the number is far worse. Infrastructure gaps, shortage of trained staff, and poor working conditions make retention in rural postings difficult. Young medical graduates cite a lack of support, safety, and growth opportunities as reasons for opting out of government service.

Compounding the strain is a growing distrust between doctors and patients. According to an IMA report nearly 75% of Indian doctors have faced violence or abuse at some point in their careers. Emergency ward assaults, mob attacks, and verbal threats have become distressingly common. Doctors report hesitating before taking on high-risk cases, fearing legal or physical backlash, an untenable position for any caregiver.



TECH AT THE FRONTLINES

And yet, there is room for optimism. India's medical landscape is undergoing visible transformation, led by both innovation and policy. The eSanjeevani telemedicine platform, launched by the Government of India, has facilitated over 14 crore consultations as of mid-2023, helping remote populations access medical advice without travel.

Meanwhile, AI-assisted diagnostics are no longer futuristic concepts. Startups like Qure.ai are using machine learning to interpret X-rays and CT scans in seconds, allowing overburdened doctors to focus on treatment rather than screening. Robotics, too, has entered the operating room, with indigenous platforms enabling minimally invasive procedures in metros and, increasingly, smaller cities. Many doctors are now being trained to adopt these tools as part of continuing medical education, helping to mainstream tech-enabled care.

Importantly, these aren't technologies replacing the doctor, they are empowering them. A well-supported physician using AI tools or remote monitoring can serve more patients with greater accuracy, while also protecting their own well-being. In time, such innovations could help bridge the quality gap between urban and rural healthcare systems.

BUILDING THE FUTURE, ONE SEAT AT A TIME

India's push to expand its healthcare workforce has been significant. Between 2014 and 2023, the number of medical colleges grew from 387 to over 700, while MBBS seats more than doubled, from around 51,000 to over 1,12,000. It's a necessary step, especially to correct the urban-rural imbalance.

But education reform isn't just about quantity, it's about mindset. Today's doctors need more than clinical proficiency. They must be equipped to handle digital tools, collaborate across systems, and communicate with empathy in multilingual, multi-cultural environments. Curriculum changes are now reflecting this shift. Some institutions have introduced modules on ethics, stress management, patient communication, and even AI literacy. The National Medical Commission has also recommended greater focus on community-based learning, where students rotate through primary care settings to understand local challenges firsthand.

By strengthening both the scientific and social dimensions of training, India can prepare a generation of doctors ready for the complexities of 21st-century care.

A SHARED RESPONSIBILITY

The theme "The Healing Touch" is not just about what doctors do, it's also a reflection of what society owes in return. Respect, yes. But also systemic support. Safety protocols. Adequate rest. Opportunities for growth. And spaces where doctors can be vulnerable without fear of judgment.

Because the future of Indian healthcare won't be shaped by technology or infrastructure alone—it will depend just as much on the people who bring it to life. And the better we care for our doctors, the better they can care for us.